

AI & SEARCH

Google AI Mode: How to Get Named in Google's Conversational Search

By Scott Tischler · September 21, 2026 · 9 min read

Google AI Mode doesn't pick a winner the way ranked search does. It takes your question, quietly breaks it into a fan of smaller sub-questions, runs all of them against the index at once, and then assembles one answer out of whichever passages best resolve each piece. So the way to get named isn't to own the #1 blue link — it's to be the cleanest, most direct answer to the specific sub-questions your topic breaks into. That's a genuinely different game than the SEO most business owners still play, and it rewards different work.

I want to be measured about this, because AI Mode is still new and moving fast. But the core mechanic is well documented now, and it lines up with what I see when I probe it: this is a synthesis engine sitting on top of Google's index, not a fancier version of the ten blue links. Once you understand how it retrieves, the optimization stops being mysterious.

What AI Mode actually does differently: query fan-out

The mechanic that matters is called query fan-out. When you ask AI Mode a real question — not "plumber near me" but "who should I hire to re-pipe a 1960s house with galvanized lines" — it doesn't just look up pages that rank for that phrase. It decomposes the question into a set of related sub-queries (materials, permits, cost ranges, common failure points, who does this kind of work) and sends each one to the index independently. A single question can trigger a whole spread of parallel searches, each pulling its own candidate passages.

Then it stitches an answer together, citing the specific passages that best resolved each sub-query. The unit of citation isn't "the page that ranked highest" — it's "the paragraph that answered this particular slice cleanly." That's why a page well outside the top organic results can still get pulled in: it happened to answer one sub-question better than anything above it.

Why your #1 ranking doesn't save you here

This is the part that catches people off guard. Ranking first for your main keyword is no longer a guarantee you show up in the AI answer. Independent analyses of AI Mode citations have found that a large share of the sources it cites don't sit in the top ten organic results for the original query at all — the overlap between "what ranks" and "what AI Mode cites" is much lower than most people assume. My read is that you should treat classic ranking and AI Mode citation as two related but separate outcomes, not one thing.

The reason is structural. If AI Mode is answering a dozen sub-questions, then twelve different pages might each win a slice — and your beautifully optimized pillar page, tuned for one head term, may not be the best answer to any single sub-question. Being broadly "relevant" to the topic loses to being the sharpest answer to a specific facet of it. That doesn't make SEO worthless; a crawlable, authoritative site is still the price of admission. It means ranking is necessary and no longer sufficient.

What actually gets pulled into the answer

Across everything I've watched and everything credible people are reporting, the passages AI Mode reaches for tend to share a handful of traits. None of these are tricks — they're what makes a passage genuinely extractable:

- **They answer immediately.** Content that resolves the specific question in its opening line gets extracted far more reliably than content that warms up for three paragraphs first. Lead with the answer, then support it.
- **They cover the whole question cluster.** If your page addresses the full spread of sub-questions a topic fans out into, you can win several citation slots at once — and you crowd out competitors who only covered the obvious angle.
- **They're structured for machines.** Clear headings, real lists, and appropriate schema (Article, FAQ, HowTo) make it easier for the system to isolate a clean passage and know what it's looking at.
- **They're fresh.** Recency carries weight. A page that visibly reflects current information tends to get chosen over one that reads as stale, all else equal.
- **They name the entity clearly.** Explicitly stating who or what you're talking about, in titles and headings, anchors the citation to the right thing instead of leaving the model to guess.

How to actually optimize for fan-out

Here's how I'd translate that into work, in order of leverage. First, stop thinking in keywords and start thinking in questions. Write down the real question a customer would ask an AI about your category, then brainstorm every sub-question it fans out into — the way you'd answer a curious friend who kept asking "okay, but what about...". Those sub-questions are your new target set.

Second, answer each one directly and in its own section, with the answer first. One clean, self-contained passage per sub-question beats one long meandering essay, because the system extracts passages, not vibes. Third, be comprehensive on purpose: the more of the question cluster a single strong page covers well, the more slots you can occupy in one synthesized answer. Fourth, keep the machine-readability basics tight — structure, schema, clean HTML — so nothing you got right gets skipped for a boring technical reason. Fifth, keep it current and date it honestly, because freshness is doing real work here. And throughout, be unmistakable about who you are, so the citation lands on your entity and not a similarly-named one.

AI Mode is not AI Overviews — don't conflate them

One trap worth naming: AI Mode and the AI Overview box you see at the top of a normal search are related but distinct surfaces, and winning one does not mean you've won the other. They cite differently. AI Overviews still lean somewhat on pages that rank for the primary query; AI Mode, with its heavier fan-out, pulls passages at a finer grain and correlates less with classic rankings. Analyses comparing the two have found the set of URLs they cite overlaps far less than you'd expect — the same question can produce two different rosters of sources depending on which surface answered it.

The practical upshot is not that you need two separate strategies — the fundamentals below serve both — but that you should measure them separately and not assume presence in one implies presence in the other. If you show up in the Overview box but never in AI Mode, that's a real gap, and it usually means your content ranks but isn't structured as clean, self-contained answers to the narrower sub-questions AI Mode fans out into. Fix the passages, not just the page.

The honest caveat

Two things keep me humble about all of this. One, AI Mode answers are volatile — ask the same question twice and the cited sources can shift. That's not a bug you can fully engineer around; it's the nature of a system fanning out and re-synthesizing each time. So don't judge your visibility off a single query. Ask repeatedly, across phrasings, and watch the pattern rather than the snapshot. Two, this is a young surface and Google will keep changing it, so treat any specific tactic as a working hypothesis, not gospel — mine included.

What I'm confident about is the direction. AI Mode rewards businesses that answer real questions cleanly, completely, and in a form a machine can lift. That's not a loophole, and it won't age badly. Build to be the best answer to the specific things your customers are actually asking, and you'll show up in the surface more of them are about to use.

Key takeaways

- ♦ Google AI Mode uses query fan-out: it splits your question into many sub-questions, searches each independently, and assembles one answer from the best passages.
- ♦ Citation happens at the passage level, not the page level — so a page outside the top organic results can still get pulled in for answering one sub-question best.
- ♦ Analyses have found a large share of AI Mode citations don't come from the top ten organic results, so classic ranking and AI Mode citation are related but separate outcomes.
- ♦ Passages that get pulled tend to answer immediately, cover the full question cluster, use clean structure and schema, stay fresh, and name the entity clearly.
- ♦ Optimize by thinking in questions and sub-questions instead of keywords, answering each one directly in its own self-contained section.
- ♦ AI Mode answers are volatile and the surface is young — judge your visibility across repeated queries, and treat any single tactic as a working hypothesis.

Frequently asked questions

What is query fan-out in Google AI Mode?

It's the core mechanic: instead of just looking up pages for your exact phrase, AI Mode breaks your question into a set of related sub-questions, runs each against Google's index independently, and then synthesizes one answer from whichever passages best resolved each piece. That's why a page can get cited for answering one narrow slice well, even if it doesn't rank at the top for the main query.

If I already rank #1 on Google, will I automatically show up in AI Mode?

Not necessarily. Ranking is still valuable and a crawlable, authoritative site is the price of admission, but independent analyses have found the overlap between top organic results and AI Mode citations is lower than most people expect. A head-term-optimized page may not be the sharpest answer to any single sub-question the fan-out produces, so treat AI Mode citation as a separate outcome you also have to earn.

How do I even check my AI Mode visibility?

Ask AI Mode the real questions your customers would ask about your category, then ask them again in different phrasings and on different days. Because answers are volatile, one query tells you almost nothing — you're looking for whether you show up consistently across repeated, varied questions, not whether you appeared once.

About the author. Scott Tischler is the Founder & Chairman of Alrecommend.ai and a practitioner-authority on AI search and Answer Engine Optimization. With 20+ years in marketing technology — including American Express, MetLife, and UBS — and executive and professional study at Wharton, Harvard, and Oxford, he helps businesses become the ones AI recommends.